

Prophylaxis starts with the opponent

Positional Judgment

THE IDEA

Prophylaxis means recognizing and limiting the opponent's useful plan. It is active thinking, not passive waiting. Prevent a move when the restriction is valuable enough to justify the time and does not concede a stronger plan elsewhere.

WORKED EXAMPLE

If the opponent wants to occupy an open file, contesting its entry square may be more efficient than immediately doubling your rooks. If a knight wants an outpost, a timely pawn move may deny it before arrival.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

How do you avoid making unnecessary preventive moves?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Name the opponent's intended move and its consequence. Compare prevention with creating a stronger threat of your own. Prevent real plans, not every imaginable possibility.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

A good preventive move answers a specific future problem.